Maldives and Sri Lanka had become Christian, ‘and a near relation of the King of Bijapur had been baptized at Goa shortly after Father Rudolf’s arrival from Europe’.[3] The Fathers made the long and difficult journey to Fatehpur in optimism, therefore, as Monserrate describes it, even if they were occasionally downcast to observe the ‘wild and savage cries’ of Muharram, or the no less ‘degraded’ celebrations of Holi. As they travelled along the western coast, from Goa to Gujarat, ever north via the forested inclines of the Satpuras, across the clear waters of the Narmada (‘the fish and turtles, and even the smallest pebbles, can be counted’) and past the royal ruins of Mandu,

the priests shook their heads at the ‘carelessness’ of the Muslim rulers of these lands, who may have destroyed some temples, but ‘allowed sacrifices to be publicly performed, incense to be offered, oil and perfumes to be poured out, the ground to be sprinkled with flowers, and wreaths to be hung up, wherever . . . any fragment of an idol is to be found’. Worse, many of the temples were now replaced by the shrines of equally ‘wicked and worthless Musalmans’.[4]

The Fathers couldn’t help having a little weep at this state of affairs, but cheered up in Gwalior, where they took the city’s famous Jain statues, carved on the walls below the Gwalior fort, for Jesus Christ and his disciples. Indeed, wrote Father Monserrate, he knew for a fact that ‘three hundred years ago this district [Gwalior] was inhabited by Christians, who were, alas, defeated in various battles by the Musalmans, and so effectively crushed that all memory of Christianity has perished from the minds of men’.

The Fathers hoped to revive that past glory, and their confidence was bolstered when they met another priest, Francis Julian Pereira, in Fatehpur. Pereira told them that Akbar was on the very brink of conversion, that he believed in Christ’s miracles, that he had paintings of Christ, Mary and Moses, alongside Muhammad, in his dining hall.[5] It only needed one last little nudge for the world’s most powerful monarch to join the Fathers’, and their nation’s, faith.

What a coup that would have been! But Pereira was wrong, and the Fathers failed – as did the two missions that followed in their wake. What they did succeed in doing, however, and with Akbar’s active